

U N I T 3 · L E S S O N 3

Forgiving Is Not the Same as Trusting

25–30 min · Week 17 · ★★ HIGHEST RISK · Counselor On-Site

O B J E C T I V E	Students distinguish between forgiveness (an inner choice for their own peace) and trust (a between-people thing that must be earned), and articulate that forgiving someone does not mean staying close to them.
C A S E L F O C U S	Social Awareness · relationship judgment; Relationship Skills: discernment about closeness
V O C A B U L A R Y	forgive · trust · earn · inside · between people · not the same · never owed
M A T E R I A L S	Sammy puppet · Forgiveness vs. Trust anchor chart · scenario cards (Unit 3 Lesson 3 cards) · COUNSELOR PHYSICALLY ON-SITE FULL LESSON

ILLINOIS SEL ALIGNMENT GRADES K-2 · EARLY ELEMENTARY

Goal 2 — Social Awareness & Interpersonal Skills

2D.1a Identify problems and conflicts commonly experienced by peers.

Goal 3 — Responsible Decision-Making

3A.1b Identify social norms and safety considerations that guide behavior.

Aligned to the Illinois Social/Emotional Learning Standards (ISBE).

SAFETY CHECK

★★ HIGHEST RISK — COUNSELOR PHYSICALLY ON-SITE THE FULL LESSON. NO EXCEPTIONS.

This lesson explicitly affirms students do NOT have to be close to people who have hurt them. Some students may be in situations where this affirmation comes as new information — and may be relieved or distressed.

CRITICAL: forgiveness is NEVER required when someone is still hurting them. State this explicitly multiple times.

Crisis resources visible: 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline · Crisis Text Line: HOME to 741741.

O P E N I N G R E V I E W · 1 – 2 M I N

Show the two-truths chart from Lesson 2. "Last lesson: understand the why AND name the hurt. Today: even if I forgive someone — do I have to be close to them again?"

S A M M Y · K I N D C O A C H V O I C E

"Someone hurt me. I am thinking about forgiving them — for ME. But I do not feel safe being close to them anymore. Is that okay?"

► DIRECT INSTRUCTION

Scripted teaching sequence · 4 STEPS · read aloud or in your own words

01 Two Different Things

5 M I N

Frame the central distinction: "Forgiveness and trust are two DIFFERENT things. Forgiveness is INSIDE — it is for YOUR peace. Trust is BETWEEN people — it is about safety. You can give forgiveness alone. You cannot give trust alone — the other person has to EARN it back."

02 Build the Two Columns

7 M I N

Build the anchor chart together. FORGIVENESS column: Inside · For your own peace · Can happen alone · Needs nothing from the other person · A gift you give yourself. TRUST column: Between people · For the safety of the relationship · Needs both people to be ready · Earned through real change · Never owed — you don't have to give it.

03 The Critical Affirmation

6 M I N

State explicitly, more than once: "You can FORGIVE someone and STILL choose not to be close to them. That is not mean. That is WISE. Forgiveness is for your peace. Trust is earned — NEVER owed. AND — forgiveness is NEVER required when someone is still hurting you."

04 Closing

4 M I N

Sammy: "I can forgive someone for my OWN peace — and still keep my distance. My safety matters. My peace matters. Both can be true."

Sammy: *"Forgiveness is for me. Trust must be earned."*

KINDERGARTEN

GRADES 1 – 2

Stay with the simplest version: "I can forgive someone — AND not have to play with them anymore." The distinction lands even if the words are big.

Discuss scenarios: a friend who keeps being mean, a sibling who broke a trust, a peer who teased then apologized. For each: should you forgive? Should you trust again? Discuss WHY.

EXIT TICKET

"'Forgiveness is for me. Trust must be earned.'" — say it together, twice. The counselor and teacher both bow."

Sammy: thumbs-up to every hand. No commentary. Sammy validates participation, not content.

TEACHER REFLECTION

CRITICAL: any student who insisted they MUST forgive AND trust someone who is still hurting them — brief the counselor immediately. They may be receiving harmful messages elsewhere.

SAFETY CHECK

POST-LESSON CLOSE-OUT · Counselor coordinates same-day debrief with teacher. Identify all students whose responses suggested ongoing harmful situations. Disclosure Protocol for any direct disclosures.

Did anything arise today requiring counselor follow-up? ☐ No ☐ Yes — contact counselor today

FAMILY CONNECTION

A Note Home

Today we learned that forgiveness and trust are two different things. We can forgive AND not be close again. AND — forgiveness is never required when someone is still hurting us. Reinforce at home: your child does NOT have to forgive someone who is still being unkind.

A N C H O R C H A R T · U N I T 3 · L E S S O N 3

Print this page · Laminate for durability · Post in classroom · Keep posted all year

ANCHOR CHART · CLASSROOM DISPLAY — PRINT ON CARDSTOCK OR 11×17, POST AS THE LESSON INDICATES

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE · BOOK 1 · THE FOUNDATION (K-2)

Forgiving Is Not the Same as Trusting

Two different things

FORGIVENESS

FORGIVENESS

- Inside
- For your own peace
- Can happen alone
- Needs nothing from the other person
- A gift you give yourself

TRUST

- Between people
- For the safety of the relationship
- Needs both people to be ready
- Earned through real change
- Never owed

You can forgive someone and still keep yourself safe.

THE ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE FOUNDATION · CONFIDENTIAL — FOR DISTRICT REVIEW ONLY

UNIT 3 · LESSON 3

CO-CONSTRUCT

Forgiveness vs. Trust

Two Separate Decisions

FORGIVENESS	TRUST
✓ Inside — for your own peace	✓ Between people — for the safety of the relationship
✓ Can happen alone, in your own heart	✓ Needs both people to be ready
✓ Needs nothing from the other person	✓ Needs the other person to show change over time
✓ Frees YOU from carrying anger	✓ Never owed — you don't have to give it
✓ A gift you give yourself	✓ Earned through real change

*You can **forgive** someone and still choose not to be close to them.
Forgiveness is for your peace. Trust is earned — never owed.*

FORGIVENESS IS NEVER REQUIRED WHEN SOMEONE IS STILL HURTING YOU.

TEACHER NOTE

Build WITH students through co-construction. Color-code columns. Keep posted for the rest of Unit 3.

SCENARIO CARDS · UNIT 3 · LESSON 3

Print · Cut vertically · Laminate · Reuse year after year

UNIT 3 · EMPATHY & FORGIVING OTHERS · JAN-MAR

Forgiving Is Not the Same as Trusting

CUT VERTICALLY · LAMINATE · REUSE

SCENARIO · 3-E

Forgiving Is Not the Same as Trusting

THE SITUATION

After Jordan told Leila's secret, she apologized sincerely. Their teacher suggested they "make up and be best friends again." Leila said she forgave Jordan but wasn't ready to be best friends again.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- ▶ Is Leila's response OK?
- ▶ What are the two separate decisions in this story?
- ▶ Can you forgive someone and still choose not to be close to them?

SCENARIO · 3-F

Forgiving Is Not the Same as Trusting

THE SITUATION

Nico was left out by a group of kids many times. His counselor encouraged him to forgive them. Nico said, "Does that mean I have to play with them again?"

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- ▶ What's your answer to Nico's question?
- ▶ Which column is forgiveness in on our chart? Which is trust?
- ▶ Help Nico understand: he can forgive AND still choose to play with other friends.

D R A W I N G E X A M P L E · U N I T 3 · L E S S O N
3

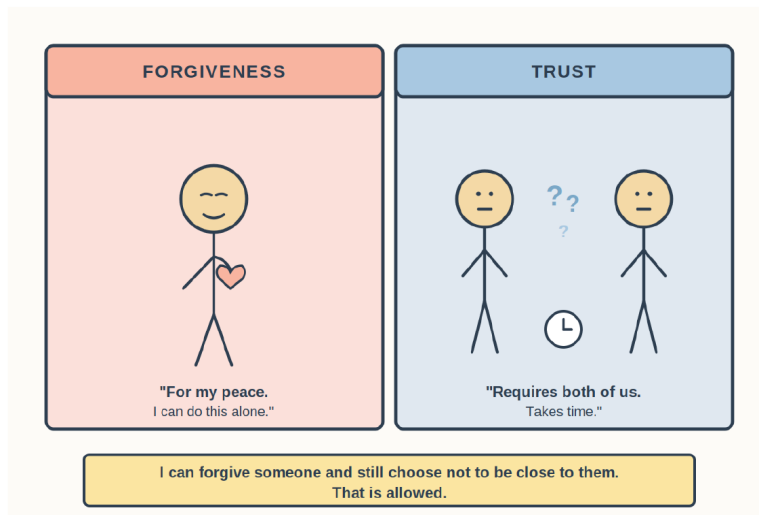
Visual reference for the drawing activity

DRAWING EXAMPLES · TEACHER REFERENCE

UNIT 3 · LESSON 3 · DRAWING EXAMPLE 11

FORGIVENESS vs. TRUST

Students illustrate the two columns of the Forgiveness vs. Trust anchor chart.



HOW TO DRAW IT

- ▶ Fold paper in two columns. Label them: FORGIVENESS (left) and TRUST (right).
- ▶ FORGIVENESS side: draw a figure with their hand on their own heart. Label: "For my peace. I can do this alone."
- ▶ TRUST side: draw two figures facing each other with question marks. Label: "Requires both of us. Takes time."
- ▶ At the bottom: "I can forgive someone and still choose not to be close to them. That is allowed."

TEACHER NOTE

Students often confuse these two. The drawing reinforces that forgiveness is internal — it doesn't require the other person to do anything.

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE

This is a free preview.

Sample Lesson · Book 1 · The Foundation (K–2)

The complete, classroom-ready curriculum — with anchor charts, worksheets, Illinois SEL alignment, and scripted Direct Instruction — is part of the Architecture of Grace district library. Educators can license the full set; families can find materials in the family store.

architectureofgrace.org